

iQOO 15

From what was a flagship killer to a full-fledged flagship

The iQOO 15 is the most expensive iQOO phone to date, and without a doubt, the most complete one I have used so far. Starting at Rs 72,999 for the 12 GB RAM and 256 GB storage variant and going up to Rs 79,999 for the 16 GB and 512 GB version, this is no longer the 'more affordable than OnePlus' kind of flagship iQOO was once known for. And yet, after using this phone as my primary device: taking it everywhere, shooting content, gaming, using navigation and binge-watching content late into the night, I can say this much with confidence: iQOO isn't trying to play the underdog anymore. This feels like the year the brand has decided to stand shoulder to shoulder with the big players, rather than nip at their heels.

Trust me when I say this, the iQOO 15 is fast in every sense of the word. It is bold in its approach, loaded to the brim with top-tier hardware, and for the first time in a long while, it truly feels like a no-compromise Android flagship from iQOO. There are no obvious weak links here, no corners that feel clearly cut just to hit a price point. I walked into this review curious and slightly sceptical because of the price hike, but after living with the phone, the picture is far more interesting than just numbers on a spec sheet. Here's my full experience with the iQOO 15. Let's dive in.

THE PRICE REALITY CHECK

Let's address the obvious first. The iQOO 13 launched at Rs 54,999 and



topped out at Rs 59,999, and the iQOO 15 now comfortably sits north of Rs 70,000. No matter how you cut it, that leap does sting. Yes, component costs have risen across the industry, and you can see that reflected in phones like the latest Vivo X and Oppo Find X flagships too, but for long-time iQOO buyers, this is still the first time the brand has felt truly expensive. The saving grace is the fairly generous bank offers, up to Rs 7,000 off, which do soften the blow and make the pricing easier to digest. At that effective price, the iQOO 15 starts to feel more like a value-heavy flagship again rather than an aspirational one.

What's interesting, though, is how this price shift changes iQOO's position in the market. For years, iQOO lived in that space just below OnePlus. That

buffer is now gone. The iQOO 15 and OnePlus 15 sit in the same price bracket, which means iQOO is no longer selling you a 'more affordable alternative', but asking to be judged as an equal. Having used both, I do feel the iQOO 15 has a few meaningful edges, especially with its absurdly bright display, dependable battery life and slightly more consistent sustained performance. At the same time, this also means iQOO gets held to a higher standard now. At this price, people will nit-pick software polish, camera tuning and long-term reliability far more than they ever did before. The iQOO 15 mostly rises to that challenge, but the shift in expectations is as big a change as the phone itself.

PERFORMANCE

Powering the iQOO 15 is the Snapdragon 8 Elite Gen 5, a name Qualcomm really needs to simplify, but a chip that absolutely flies. Paired with up to 16 GB LPDDR5X RAM and 512 GB UFS 4.1 storage, everything on this phone feels instant. I can barely think of a moment when I felt the phone was lagging or if there was even a minor stutter. App launches are fast, multitasking is fluid, and the touch response is precise while gaming. I would point out that there was a bit of shutter lag while taking photos at night, but that seems to have sorted with the latest software build (PD2505F_EX_A_16.0.18.6.W30) of OriginOS 6. More on this in a bit.

Benchmark numbers also back the performance. Geekbench 6 scores stand at 3,563 for single-core and 10,029 for multi-core. Antutu pushed past 3.73 mil-

